

Michael Graves

One of the most important exponents of postmodernism, Michael Graves (1934–2015) began by creating modernist white geometric volumes; in the late 1960s he was classed as one of the New York Five, a group of influential East Coast modernists. Yet by the late 1970s, he sought a more diverse expression. In 1977, he designed Plocek House in New Jersey: a building reminiscent of an Italian palazzo, with classical yet abstracted columns and an exaggerated entrance arch. The use of colour, and small windows in place of large expanses of glass, signposted his move to postmodernism. In 1979–82, he designed the Portland Building in Oregon, with colourful façades decorated with a stylized garland and pilasters (opposite). The building's flamboyance and dark interiors created by small windows initially caused great controversy. His 26-storey Humana Building (1982–5) in Louisville has a granite and marble façade, and his El Gouna Resort Hotel (1995) in Egypt features rendered concrete, domed roofs and chimney-like projections, blending postmodern elements with vernacular architecture.

